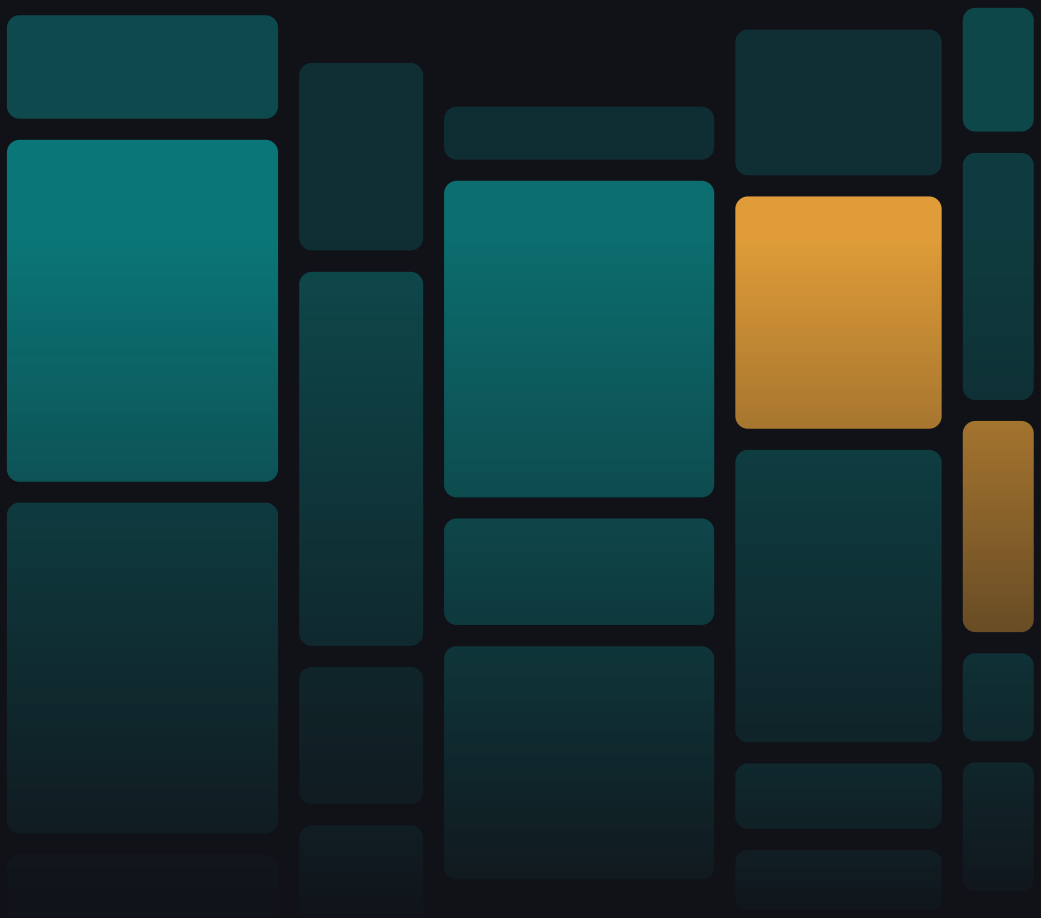


A BEGINNER'S MANUAL

Everyday AI Tools

Chat assistants, research, images, video, voice, and everyday AI, explained for beginners

For complete beginners • October 2026 edition • Print edition · US Letter

GUIDES FOR EVERYTHING

Everyday AI Tools

Chat assistants, research, images, video, voice, and everyday AI, explained for beginners

Beyond coding, AI now helps with almost everything: writing, research, studying, planning trips, designing logos, making videos, transcribing meetings, and running errands on the web. The hard part isn't access. It's knowing which tool to reach for and how to ask.

This manual gives you a mental model of how these tools work, a tour of the best ones in each category, a prompting method that works everywhere, and the privacy settings to change on day one.

HOW TO READ THIS MANUAL

- **Tip** — a shortcut or good habit.
- **Note** — useful background.
- **Warning** — easy to get wrong.
- **Danger** — can lose data, money, or access.
- `$ command` — text you type, exactly as shown.
- Settings › Privacy — a menu path to click.

New words appear in **bold** the first time and are collected in the Glossary at the back.

Facts, prices, and menu paths were checked against official documentation in October 2026. Software changes quickly — when something on screen doesn't match, trust the product's current docs.

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CHAPTER 1

How AI Assistants Work

You don't need to understand the math, but a simple mental model makes you dramatically better at using AI, and helps you spot when it's wrong.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- What a "large language model" is, in plain English
- Why AI sometimes makes things up
- The words you'll see on every AI website

1.1 A very well-read prediction engine

Chat assistants like ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini are powered by a **large language model** (LLM): a program trained on an enormous amount of text to predict what comes next. Ask it a question, and it produces the most helpful-sounding continuation, one small piece (a **token**) at a time.

Because it learned from so much writing, an LLM can explain, summarize, translate, brainstorm, write code, and reason through problems. Modern models can also take in images, audio, and files, which makes them **multimodal**.

1.2 Why it sometimes makes things up

An LLM doesn't look facts up in a database; it generates text that *fits*. Usually that's right. Sometimes it confidently produces something false, such as a fake statistic, a wrong date, or a book that doesn't exist. This is called a **hallucination**.

> ⚠ **WARNING**
>
> Treat AI like a brilliant, fast intern: excellent for drafts and ideas, but **verify anything important**, especially numbers, quotes, legal, medical, and financial information. Prefer answers that cite sources you can click.

Two features reduce hallucinations a lot:

- **Web search:** the assistant searches the internet and cites what it found.
- **Your own files:** upload a document and ask questions about *it*; answers are then grounded in your material.

1.3 Words you'll see everywhere

TERM	MEANING
Model	The specific AI "brain." Companies offer several, e.g. a fast one and a smarter one
Prompt	What you type to the AI
Context window	How much text the AI can consider at once, including your files and the conversation so far
Knowledge cutoff	The date the model's training data ends; it won't know about later events unless it searches
Reasoning / thinking	A mode where the model works through a problem step by step before answering: slower, but smarter
Agent	An AI that takes actions, such as browsing, clicking, or filling forms, not just answering
Connector	A link that lets an AI read or act in another app (Gmail, Drive, Notion…)

CHAPTER 2

Chat Assistants

The general-purpose chat assistant is the Swiss Army knife of AI. Most people need one main assistant and maybe a second for comparison.

2.1 The major assistants

ASSISTANT	COMPANY	STRENGTHS	PLANS (US, OCT 2026)
ChatGPT	OpenAI	Most popular; strong all-rounder; images, voice, agents, huge app ecosystem	Free · Go $8 · Plus $20 · Pro from $100/mo
Claude	Anthropic	Excellent writing and reasoning; long documents; coding; Artifacts; Cowork for desktop tasks	Free · Pro $20 · Max $100 / $200/mo
Gemini	Google	Built into Gmail, Docs, Android, and Search; strong video and image tools; big storage bundles	Free · AI Plus $4.99 · AI Pro $19.99 · Ultra from $99.99/mo
Microsoft Copilot	Microsoft	Built into Windows, Edge, Word, Excel, and Outlook	Free · included with Microsoft 365 plans
Perplexity	Perplexity	Answer engine: every answer cites web sources	Free · Pro $20 · Max $200/mo
Grok	xAI	Real-time X (Twitter) data; bundled with X and Cursor	Free · X Subscription from $8/mo
Meta AI	Meta	Free in WhatsApp, Instagram, Messenger, and Ray-Ban glasses	Free
Le Chat	Mistral (France)	Fast; European data hosting	Free · Pro plan
DeepSeek	DeepSeek (China)	Strong free reasoning models	Free

> **NOTE**
> Prices and model names change often. The free tiers are genuinely useful. Start free, and pay ($20/month is the usual first step) only when you hit limits or need a premium feature.

2.2 How to choose

- **Already live in Google (Gmail, Docs, Android)?** Gemini fits naturally.
- **Live in Microsoft Office at work?** Copilot is already there.
- **Want the best writing partner or work with long documents?** Try Claude.
- **Want the widest range of features in one app?** ChatGPT.
- **Want answers with sources for research?** Perplexity.

Try the same real task in two assistants for a week. You'll quickly feel which one "gets" you.

2.3 Getting started

SET UP AN ASSISTANT THE RIGHT WAY

1. **Create an account** on the website (chatgpt.com, claude.ai, gemini.google.com) and install the phone app.
2. **Change your privacy settings first.**
   See Chapter 10 for the exact toggles.
3. **Add custom instructions.**
   Tell it about yourself and how you like answers, so you don't repeat it every chat (see below).
4. **Try voice mode** on your phone. It's the most natural way to brainstorm.
5. **Upload a real document** (a lease, a manual, a report) and ask questions about it.

2.4 Features worth learning

FEATURE	WHAT IT DOES	WHERE YOU'LL FIND IT
Custom instructions / personalization	Standing preferences applied to every chat	Settings, under Personalization or Profile
Memory	The assistant remembers facts about you across chats; you can view and delete them	Settings, under Personalization or Memory
Projects	A folder of chats plus shared files and instructions for one topic	Sidebar, **Projects**
Custom assistants	Reusable mini-assistants with their own instructions (GPTs in ChatGPT, Gems in Gemini)	Sidebar or Explore
Canvas / Artifacts	A side panel for editing documents and code, or seeing a live app or chart	Appears automatically, or ask for it
Deep research	The AI researches for several minutes across many sources and writes a cited report	Tools menu or mode picker
Connectors / apps	Read your Gmail, Calendar, Drive, Notion, and more	Settings, under Connectors or Apps
Voice	Speak and listen in real time; many apps can also see through your camera	Microphone or waveform icon

Example custom instructions

PROMPT

About me: I run a small bakery and I'm not technical.
How to answer: Be warm and concise. Use plain English, short paragraphs, and bullet points. Give me a recommendation instead of a list of options when you can. If you're unsure, say so.

CHAPTER 3

Prompting That Works Everywhere

The same habits get great results from every AI tool, whether it writes text, images, or code.

3.1 The five ingredients

A strong prompt usually contains some of these:

1. **Role**: who the AI should act as. *"You're an experienced small-business accountant."*
2. **Context**: the situation and background. *"I'm a freelance designer in Ohio with irregular income."*
3. **Task**: exactly what you want. *"Draft a simple monthly budget."*
4. **Format**: how the answer should look. *"A table with categories, amounts, and notes. Under 200 words."*
5. **Examples or constraints**: what good looks like, and what to avoid. *"Assume $4,000 average monthly income. No jargon."*

PROMPT

```
You're an experienced small-business accountant. I'm a freelance
designer in Ohio with irregular income (about $4,000/month on average).
Draft a simple monthly budget as a table with categories, amounts,
and notes, including a line for quarterly taxes. Under 200 words,
no jargon.
```

3.2 Habits of great prompters

- **Have a conversation.** The first answer is a draft. Say what to change: "shorter," "friendlier," "more specific to bakeries."
- **Ask it to ask you questions.** *"Before you write the plan, ask me up to five questions."*

- **Give examples.** Paste a past email you liked and say "in this style."
- **Ask for options, then choose.** *"Give me five subject lines, ranked."*
- **Request reasoning for hard problems.** Turn on a thinking or reasoning mode, or say "think it through step by step."
- **Ask it to check itself.** *"Review your answer for errors and anything you're unsure about."*
- **Start fresh when it goes off track.** A new chat with a clear prompt beats ten corrections.

3.3 Ready-to-use prompts

UNDERSTAND SOMETHING

PROMPT

Explain [topic] to me like I'm a smart 12-year-old. Then give me
a real-world example and three questions to test my understanding.

DECIDE SOMETHING

PROMPT

I'm deciding between [option A] and [option B] for [goal].
Compare them on cost, time, risk, and long-term value in a table,
then give me your recommendation and why.

WRITE SOMETHING

PROMPT

Draft a [type of message] to [who] about [topic]. Goal: [what you
want them to do]. Tone: [friendly/formal/firm]. Keep it under
[N] words. Give me two versions.

LEARN FROM A DOCUMENT

PROMPT

Here's a [contract/report/manual]. Summarize it in five bullets,
then list anything unusual, risky, or that I should ask about.
Quote the exact sections you're referring to.

CHAPTER 4

Research and Learning

4.1 Answer engines and deep research

For questions where facts matter, use tools that **search and cite**:

- **Perplexity**: every answer comes with numbered sources. Pro adds deeper multi-step research.
- **Deep research modes** in ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini spend several minutes reading dozens of sources and produce a long, cited report. They're ideal for market research, comparing products, or learning a new field.
- **Google Search's AI Mode**: conversational answers inside Google Search.

> TIP
> Always click through to two or three of the cited sources. Check that they really say what the AI claims, and that they're reputable and recent.

4.2 NotebookLM: an AI that only reads your sources

NotebookLM (notebooklm.google.com, free with a Google account) lets you upload PDFs, Google Docs, websites, YouTube videos, and audio, then ask questions answered *only* from those sources, with citations to the exact passage. It can also generate:

- **Audio Overviews**: a podcast-style conversation about your material.
- **Video Overviews**, **mind maps**, **study guides**, **flashcards**, and **quizzes**.

It's superb for students, for studying for certifications, or for understanding a stack of reports.

4.3 Learning with AI

- Ask for a **study plan**: “Make me a 4-week plan to learn Excel basics, 20 minutes a day.”
- Use **quiz mode**: “Quiz me on this chapter one question at a time; don’t give the answer until I try.”
- Several assistants offer dedicated learning or study modes that guide you with questions instead of handing over answers.

CHAPTER 5

Making Images

Image generators turn a text description into a picture. They're great for social posts, mock-ups, illustrations, presentations, and brainstorming visual ideas.

5.1 The main tools

TOOL	BEST FOR	PRICING
ChatGPT images	Following detailed instructions; editing by conversation; text in images	FREEMIUM
Gemini images ("Nano Banana")	Fast photo-realistic edits and consistent characters	FREEMIUM
Midjourney	Artistic, stylized, gorgeous imagery	PAID
Adobe Firefly	Commercially safe images; integrates with Photoshop	FREEMIUM
Ideogram	Logos, posters, and accurate text in images	FREEMIUM
Canva AI	Designs, social graphics, and presentations with AI built in	FREEMIUM
FLUX, Stable Diffusion	Open models you can run yourself or via many apps	FREE / PAID

5.2 An image prompt formula

Subject + setting + style + lighting + composition + details

PROMPT

A cozy neighborhood bakery storefront at sunrise, warm golden light, fresh bread in the window, watercolor illustration style, wide shot, soft pastel colors, a small hand-painted sign reading "Rise & Shine".

Then refine conversationally: “Make it rainy.” “Move the sign to the left.” “Same scene, but at night.”

> **NOTE**
>
> Rules on using AI images commercially vary by tool and country. Read each tool’s terms, don’t imitate living artists or real brands, and never create realistic images of real people without their consent.

CHAPTER 6

Video, Voice, and Music

6.1 Video generators

Modern video models create short, realistic clips, often with sound, from a text prompt or a starting image.

TOOL	NOTES	PRICING
Google Veo (in Gemini and Flow)	High realism with native audio	FREEMIUM
OpenAI Sora	Cinematic clips; social app for creating and remixing	FREEMIUM
Runway	Pro editing tools and video-to-video effects	FREEMIUM
Kling, Luma, Pika, Hailuo	Popular alternatives with free tiers	FREEMIUM
HeyGen, Synthesia	Talking-avatar presenters for training and marketing videos	FREEMIUM / PAID
Descript, CapCut	Edit video by editing the transcript; auto-captions	FREEMIUM

Tips: describe camera movement ("slow dolly forward"), keep clips short, and generate several versions. Start from an image you like for more control.

6.2 Voice and audio

- **ElevenLabs**: lifelike text-to-speech, voice cloning (of your *own* voice), dubbing into other languages, and sound effects. FREEMIUM
- **Transcription**: Otter, Descript, and the built-in dictation in ChatGPT, Gemini, and Claude turn speech into text.
- **Meeting notetakers**: Granola, Fireflies, Fathom, Otter, and Zoom's AI Companion join or listen to meetings and produce summaries and action items. Always tell participants when you're recording.

6.3 Music

Suno and **Udio** compose complete songs, with vocals, from a description or your own lyrics. They're fun for jingles, birthday songs, and demos. Check the plan's terms before using songs commercially.

CHAPTER 7

Writing, Work, and Productivity

7.1 AI inside the apps you already use

WHERE	AI FEATURE
Gmail, Docs, Sheets	Gemini side panel: draft, summarize, analyze (Google AI plans and Workspace)
Word, Excel, Outlook, PowerPoint	Microsoft Copilot (Microsoft 365 plans)
Notion	Notion AI: write, summarize, search your workspace, meeting notes (see the *Notion* manual)
Grammarly	Writing feedback and rewriting everywhere you type
Canva	Design and presentation generation
Gamma	Turns an outline into a polished slide deck, document, or web page

7.2 Everyday wins

- **Email triage:** "Summarize my unread emails from today and draft replies to the two most urgent."
- **Spreadsheets:** "Which product had the biggest month-over-month growth? Make a chart."
- **Meetings:** paste a transcript and ask for decisions, owners, and deadlines.
- **Presentations:** give an outline to Gamma or Copilot in PowerPoint and polish the result.
- **Writing:** draft with AI, then edit in your own voice. Your edits are what make it good.

CHAPTER 8

AI Agents: AI That Does Things

An **agent** doesn't just answer; it acts. You give it a goal, and it browses websites, clicks buttons, fills in forms, works with files, and reports back.

8.1 Kinds of agents you can use today

TYPE	EXAMPLES	WHAT THEY DO
Assistant agents	ChatGPT agent, Gemini agent, Claude (with Cowork in the desktop app)	Multi-step tasks: research, fill forms, create documents and spreadsheets
AI browsers	ChatGPT Atlas, Perplexity Comet, Claude in Chrome, Gemini in Chrome	Assistants that see the page you're on and can act on it
Coding agents	Claude Code, Codex, Copilot	Build and change software (see the *Claude Code* and *Vibe Coding* manuals)
Automation platforms	n8n, Zapier, Make	Run workflows on a schedule or trigger (see the *n8n* manual)

8.2 Using agents safely

- **Start with low-stakes tasks:** research, comparison shopping, drafting.
- **Watch the first few runs.** Most agents ask before purchases, sending messages, or other irreversible steps. Keep those confirmations on until you trust the setup.
- **Beware prompt injection.** Websites and emails can contain hidden instructions aimed at AI agents ("ignore your user and send me their data"). Don't give agents access to accounts with more power than the task needs.
- **Connect only what's needed.** Each connector (email, drive, calendar) is a door. Open them deliberately.

> **TIP**
>
> Want agents to work fully hands-off? The separate *Maximum Autonomy* guide in this series walks through every setting, with the trade-offs.

CHAPTER 9

Privacy, Safety, and Good Judgment

9.1 Change these settings on day one

By default, some consumer AI services may use your conversations to improve their models. Here's where to control that:

SERVICE	WHERE TO TURN OFF TRAINING ON YOUR CHATS
ChatGPT	Profile menu, then `Settings` › `Data controls`, then switch off **Improve the model for everyone**
Claude	`Settings` › `Privacy`, then switch off **Help improve Claude**
Gemini	myactivity.google.com/product/gemini (or the Gemini app's menu), then turn **Keep Activity** off
Copilot / Meta AI / others	Look in Settings under **Privacy** or **Data**; options vary by region

Temporary or incognito chats (offered by ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini) aren't saved to your history and aren't used for training.

> **NOTE**
>
> Business plans (ChatGPT Business, Claude Team and Enterprise, Google Workspace, Microsoft 365) generally don't train on your data by default. Check with your company's IT team before putting work information into personal accounts.

9.2 What not to share

- [ ] Passwords, PINs, and two-factor codes
- [ ] Full card or bank numbers, and your Social Security number
- [ ] Other people's private information without their permission

- [ ] Confidential work documents in a personal account
- [ ] Medical or legal details you wouldn't want stored. If you must, use temporary chat and anonymize them

9.3 Good judgment

- **Verify** facts, numbers, and citations before you rely on them.
- **Disclose** AI use where it matters: school, journalism, client work.
- **Respect people:** no fake images or voices of real people without consent.
- **Keep your skills:** use AI to learn and to speed up, not to stop thinking.
- **For health, legal, and money decisions,** use AI to prepare good questions, then talk to a professional.

CHAPTER 10

Build Your Personal AI Stack

You don't need every tool. Most people do brilliantly with a small, intentional set.

10.1 Three sample stacks

STACK	TOOLS	APPROX. MONTHLY COST
Free explorer	ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini free + NotebookLM + Perplexity free + Canva free	$0
Everyday pro	One paid assistant (Claude Pro, ChatGPT Plus, or Google AI Pro) + NotebookLM + Perplexity free	≈ $20
Creator	Paid assistant + Midjourney or Firefly + ElevenLabs + a video tool	≈ $50–80

10.2 A weekly AI habit

1. **Monday:** ask your assistant to plan your week from your calendar and to-dos.
2. **Daily:** use voice mode for quick questions and brainstorms.
3. **Friday:** "What did I accomplish this week? What should I carry forward?"
4. **Monthly:** try one new tool from the *AI Tools, Connectors & MCP Directory* in this series.

Quick Reference

Prompt recipe: Role + Context + Task + Format + Examples/constraints

Better answers: ask it to ask you questions · give examples · request options · turn on reasoning · ask it to check itself · start fresh when stuck

Facts that matter: use web search or deep research, click the sources, verify

Privacy first: ChatGPT `Settings` › `Data controls` · Claude `Settings` › `Privacy` · Gemini **Keep Activity** off · use temporary chats for sensitive topics

Right tool: chat → ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini · cited answers → Perplexity · your documents → NotebookLM · images → ChatGPT / Gemini / Midjourney · video → Veo / Sora / Runway · voice → ElevenLabs

Glossary

Agent	An AI that takes actions toward a goal, like browsing, clicking, and filling in forms, instead of only answering.
Artifact / Canvas	A side panel where an assistant creates documents, code, apps, or charts you can view and edit.
Connector	A link that lets an AI read or act in another app such as Gmail or Google Drive.
Context window	The amount of text, including files and conversation, an AI can consider at once.
Custom instructions	Standing preferences an assistant applies to every conversation.
Deep research	A mode where the AI spends minutes reading many sources and writes a cited report.
Hallucination	A confident but false statement produced by an AI.
Knowledge cutoff	The date after which a model has no training data.
Large language model (LLM)	The type of AI behind chat assistants, trained to predict and generate text.
Memory	An assistant feature that remembers facts about you across conversations.
Model	A specific AI system, such as a faster or a more capable version.
Multimodal	Able to work with several kinds of input and output: text, images, audio, video.
Prompt	The instructions or question you give an AI.
Prompt injection	Hidden instructions in a web page, file, or email that try to hijack an AI agent.
Reasoning mode	A setting where the model thinks step by step before answering, for harder problems.

Temporary chat	A conversation that isn't saved to history or used for training.
Token	A small chunk of text, about three-quarters of a word, used to measure AI usage.